



STATE OF UX IN HAWAI'I

2022

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The Purpose

UXHI conducted this study to get a better understanding of the UX landscape here in Hawai'i. This will be the first research report that we are aware of on this topic in Hawai'i.

We hope that the results of this study will help **support tech job creation, increase UX awareness, and give** us a better understanding of our UX community in Hawai'i.

A decorative graphic consisting of approximately 15 small triangles of various colors (orange, yellow, teal, and purple) arranged in a loose, curved pattern on the left side of the slide.

But first... what is UX?

Formal Definition of UX

UX stands for “user experience”. To many, it is assumed that UX refers to just the visual interface of a digital product. However, members and advocates of the field define UX as much more than that. According to Don Norman and Jakob Nielsen, who are believed to be the founders of UX, define the field as:

User experience encompasses **all aspects of the end-user's interaction with the company, its services, and its products.**

Some UX Definitions from Our Community ⁵

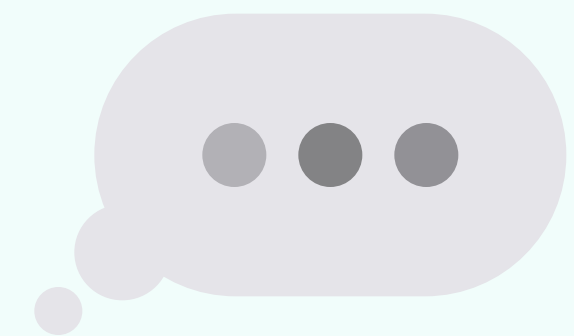
Research, testing, identifying pain points.

As UX people we need to remember it's about humans.

User experience is an opportunity to explore what will help both users and clients 'win.' We aim to delight and engage users, but also determine how to help our clients meet their goals as well.

UX is really just trying to solve problems with the user in mind, empowering them to do what they need to accomplish those things. Helping users.

A purposeful organization and systematic way for the user in order to fulfill the most seamless, gratifying and omnichannel experience for delight and functionality.



Our Methods & Participants



74

QUANTITATIVE

Survey responses

Between Nov 2021 to Jan 2022, we sent the survey out to our UXHI community which consists of UX-related individuals either in, adjacent to, or looking to transition into the field.

This survey was about 5 minutes long with 25 questions.

Our reach was via our email newsletter, social media, and Slack.



15

QUALITATIVE

In-depth interviews

In Jan and Feb 2022, we conducted semi-directive interviews with UX educators, practitioners, and allies. Some of these individuals were also our survey participants.

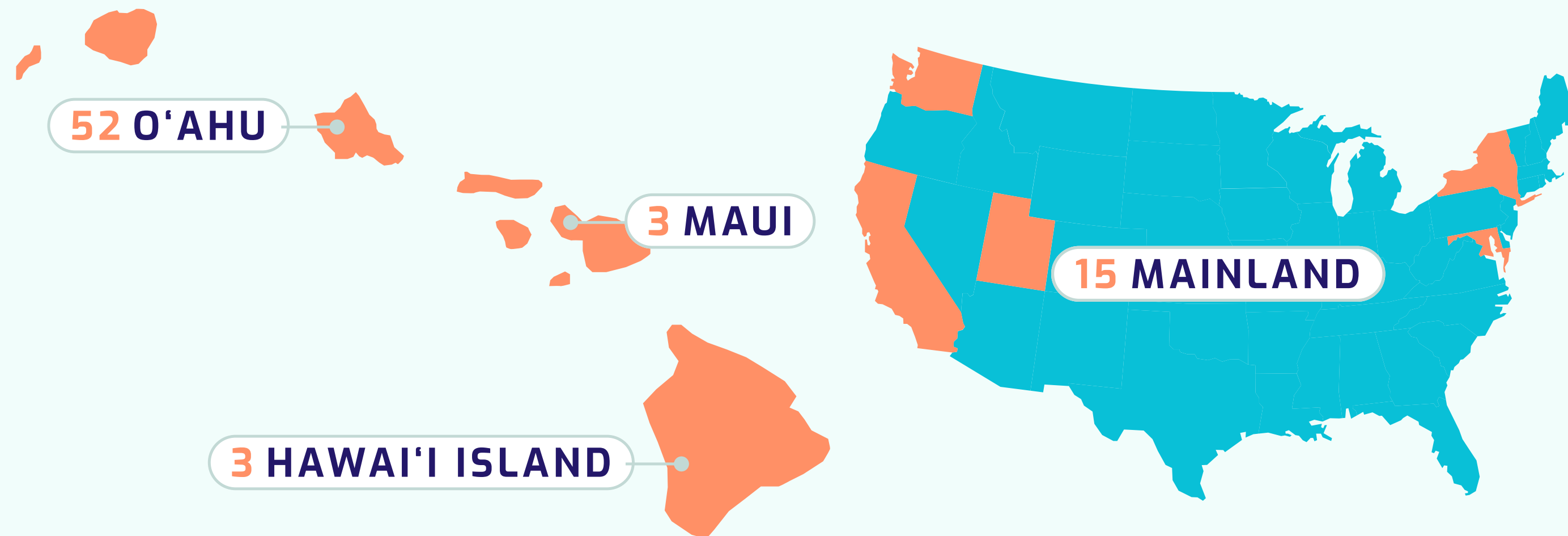
Each session was about 60 minutes long with 1 facilitator and 1 notetaker. Notes were captured in Google Docs and then translated to FigJam for affinity mapping. This report consists of findings from both sources of data.





Survey Participants

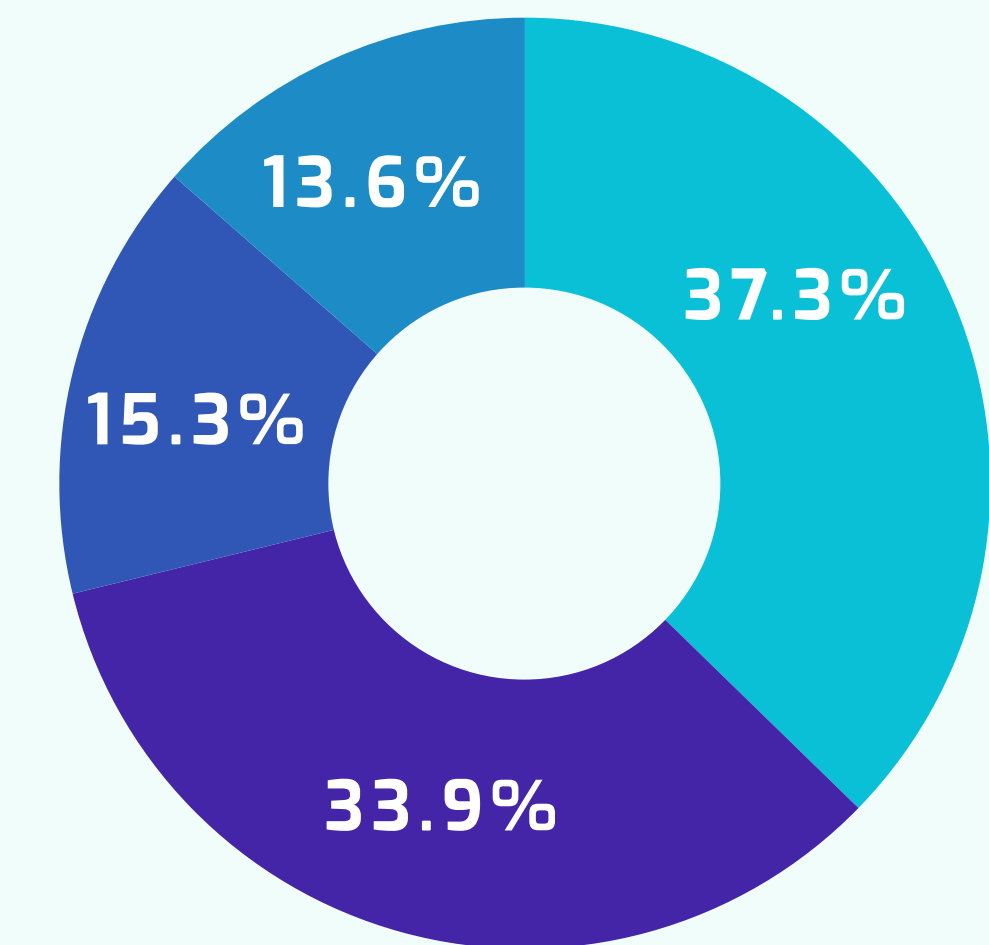
Location



:: Where you stay?

59 out of the 74 participants currently reside in the state of Hawai'i. Furthermore, 57% of current residents intend to stay permanently.

Out of those residing in Hawai'i, more than half of them grew up here whereas the rest of participants moved here before or during the pandemic.

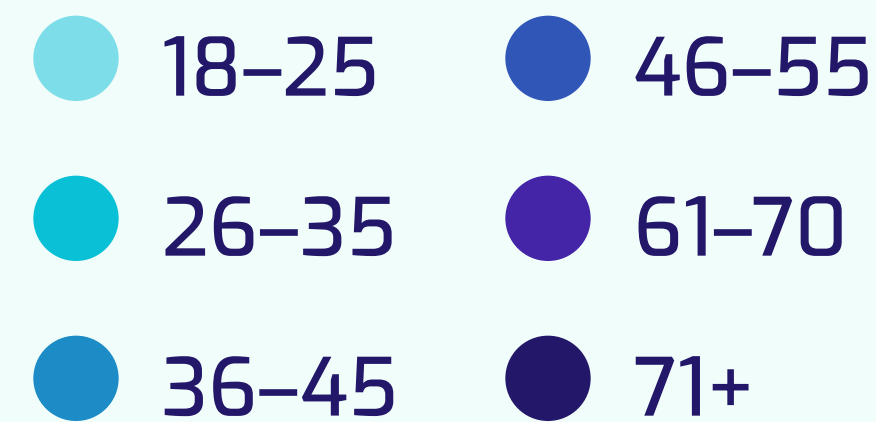
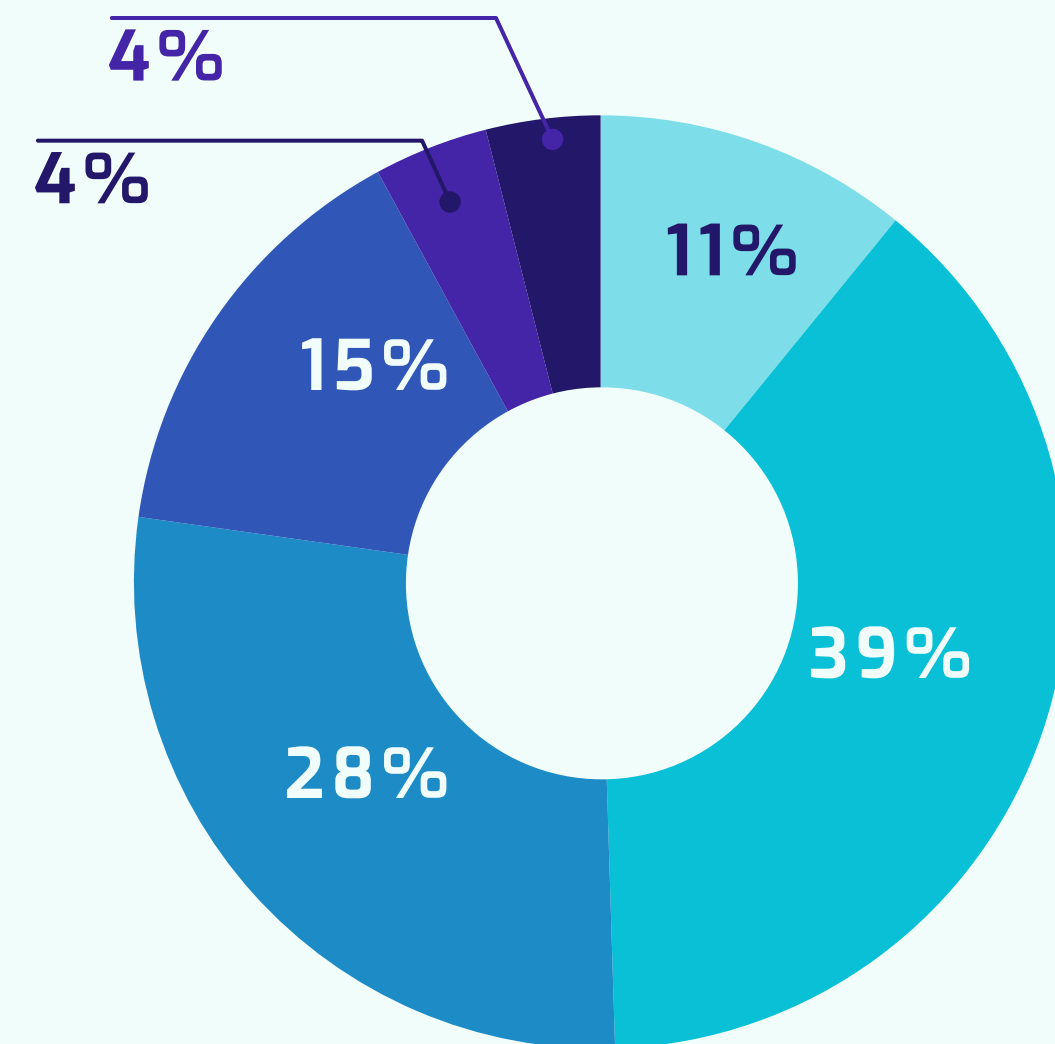


:: History living in Hawai'i?

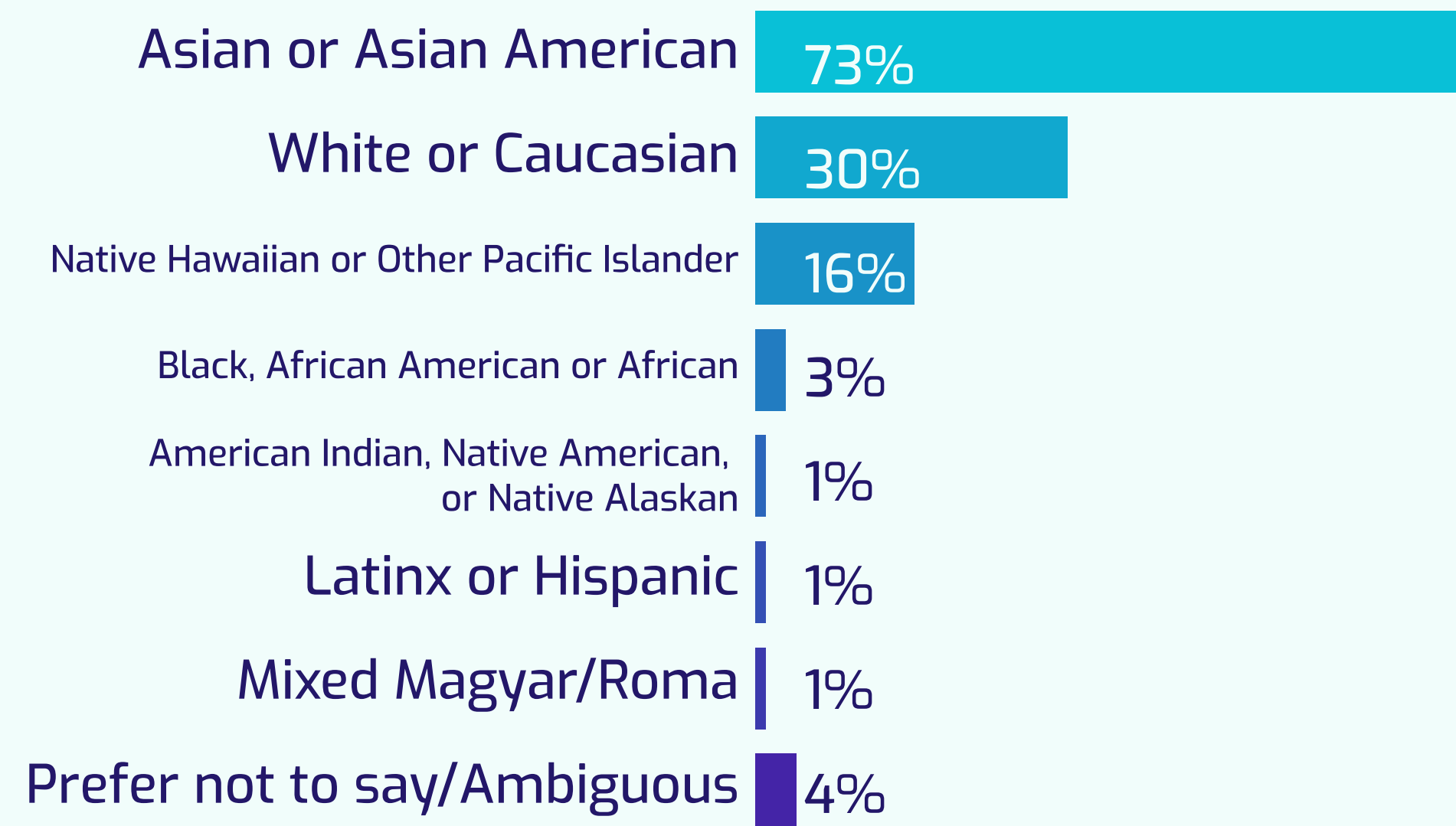
- I grew up here, moved away, and returned.
- I moved here from out-of-state before the COVID-19 pandemic
- I grew up here, and still reside here.
- I moved here from out-of-state during the COVID-19 pandemic.

Demographics

:: Age

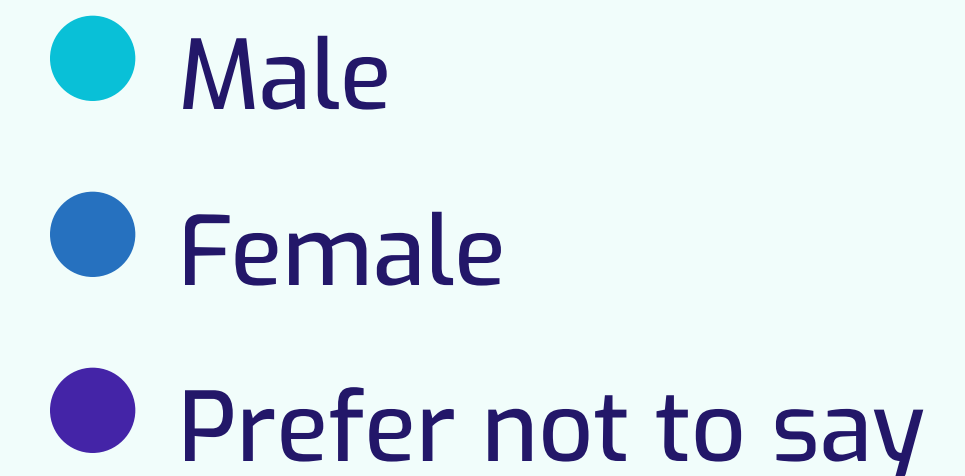
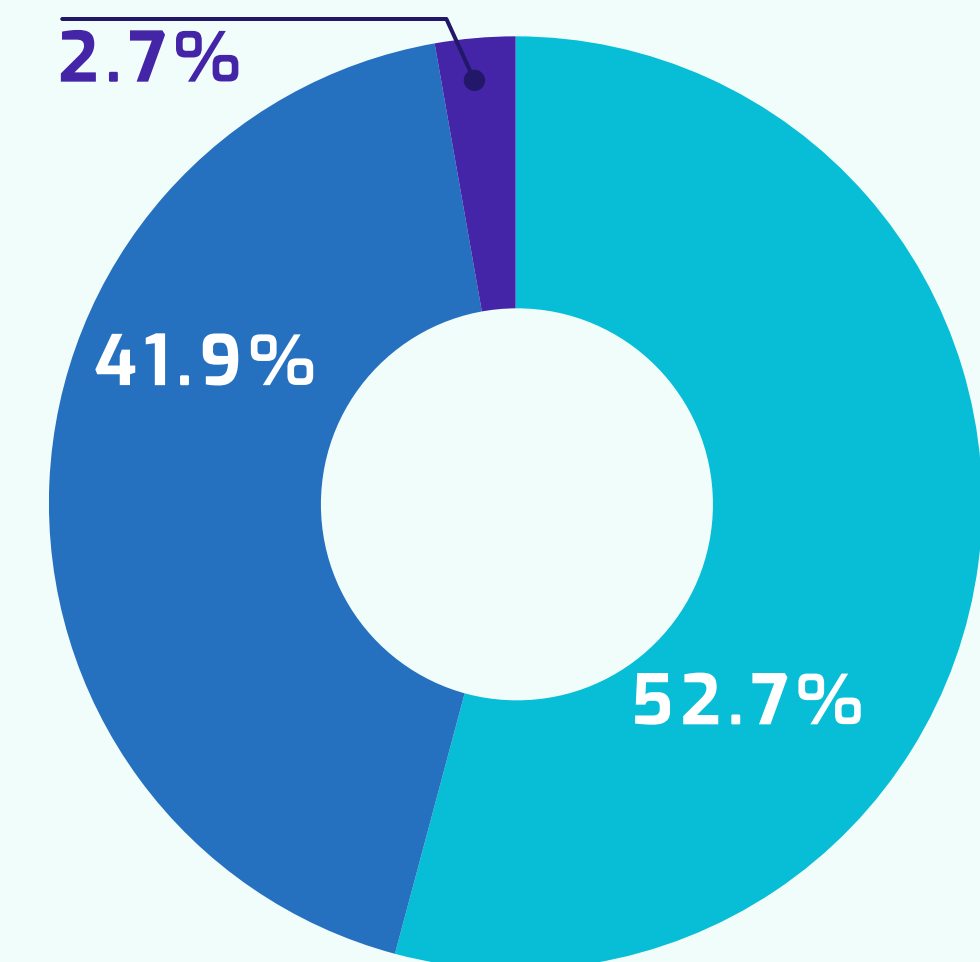


:: Race & Ethnicity



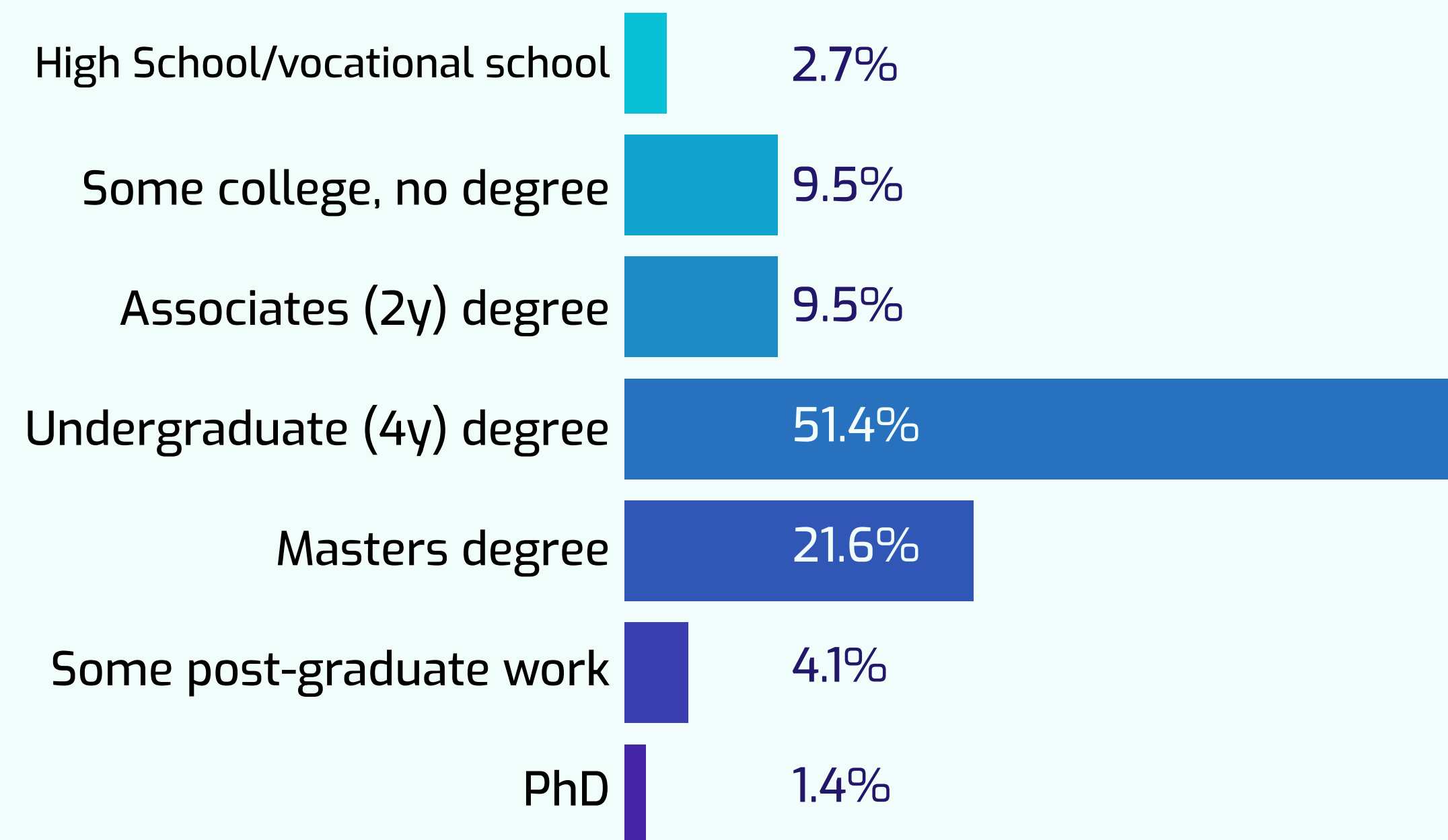
The percentages above reflect the number of participants that identified with each race/ethnicity. Therefore, the total sum of percentages is greater than 100% because many participants are multiethnic or multiracial.

:: Gender



Education & Degree

:: Highest Degree

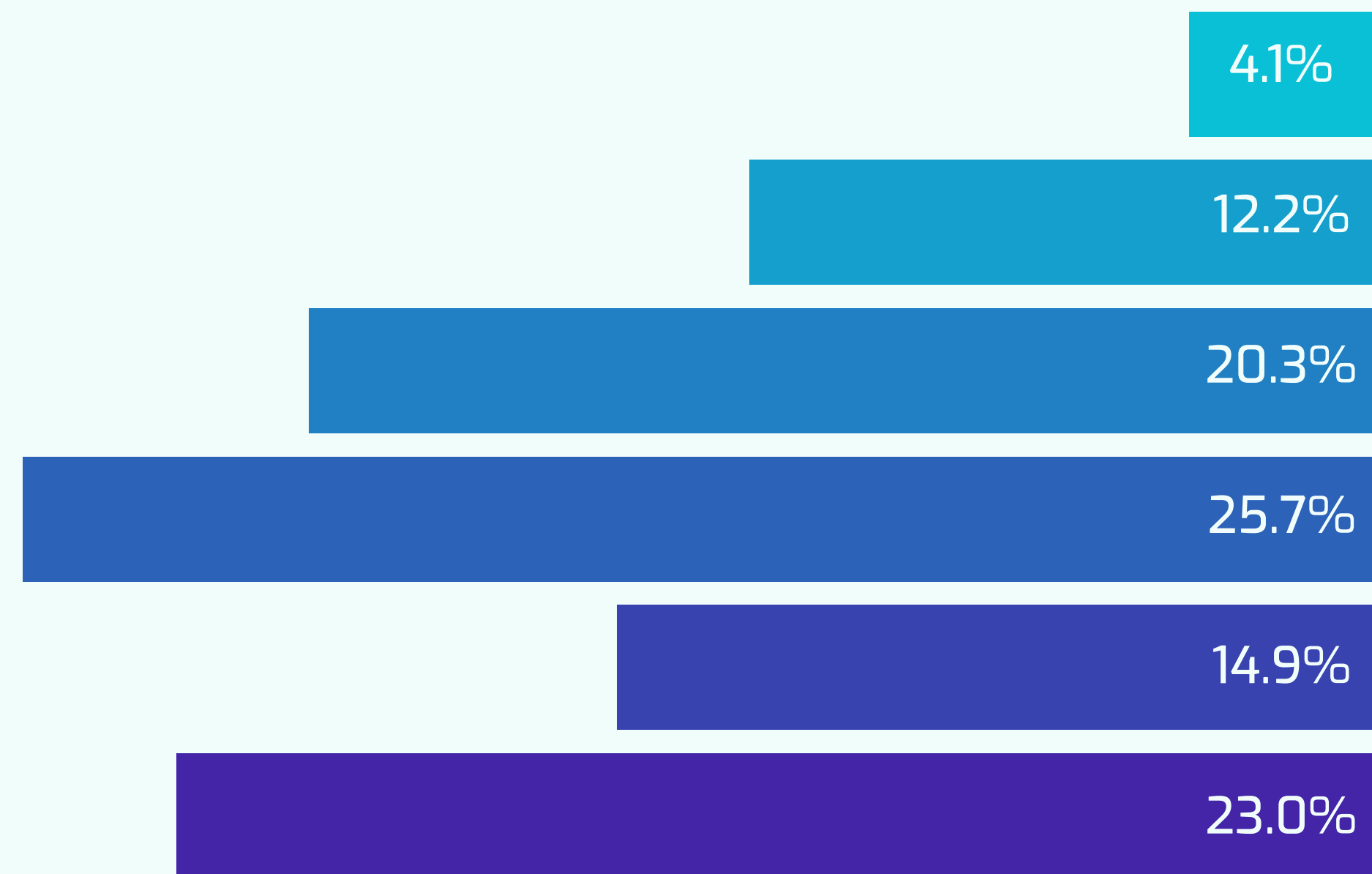


:: Degree in Education

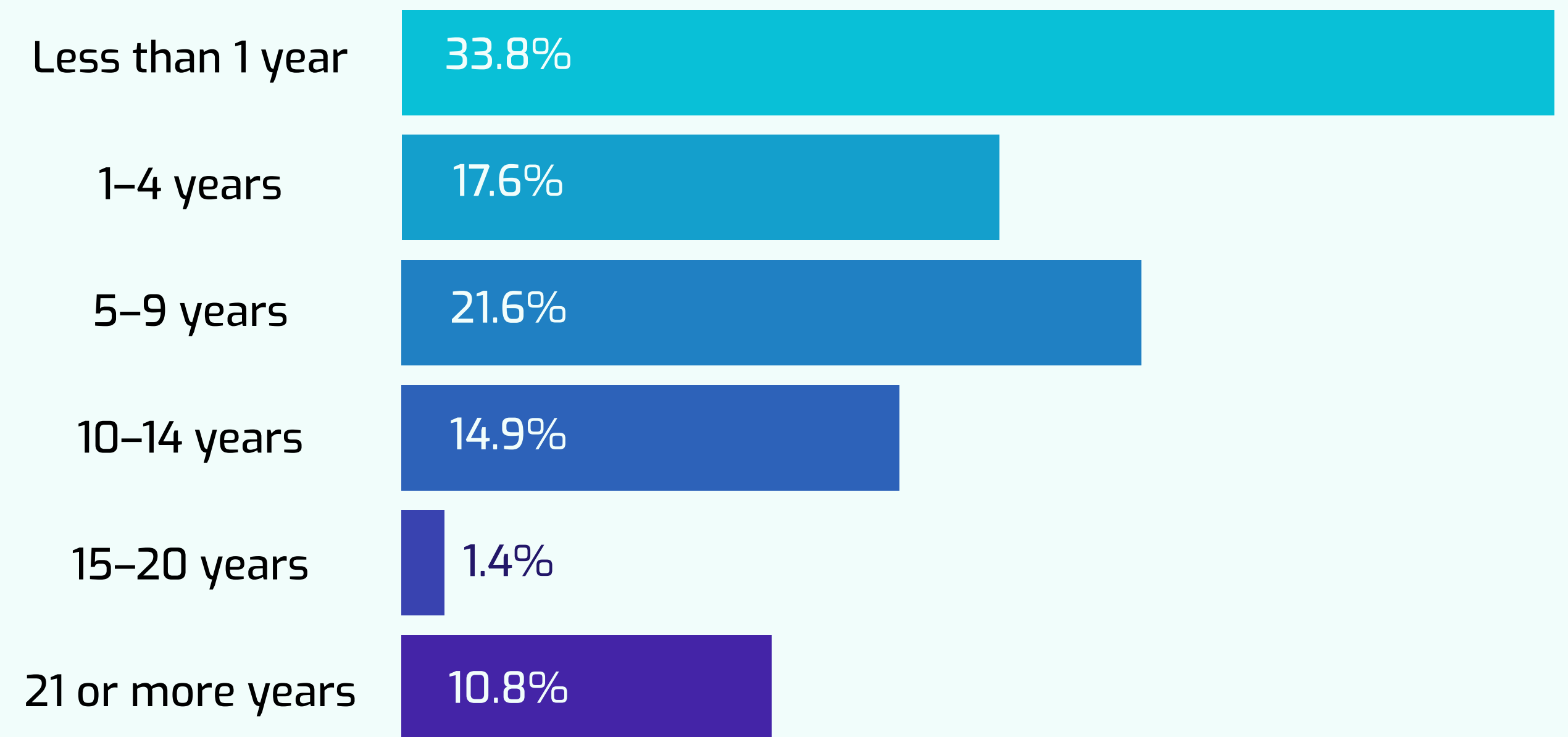


Work Experience

:: Overall Work Experience



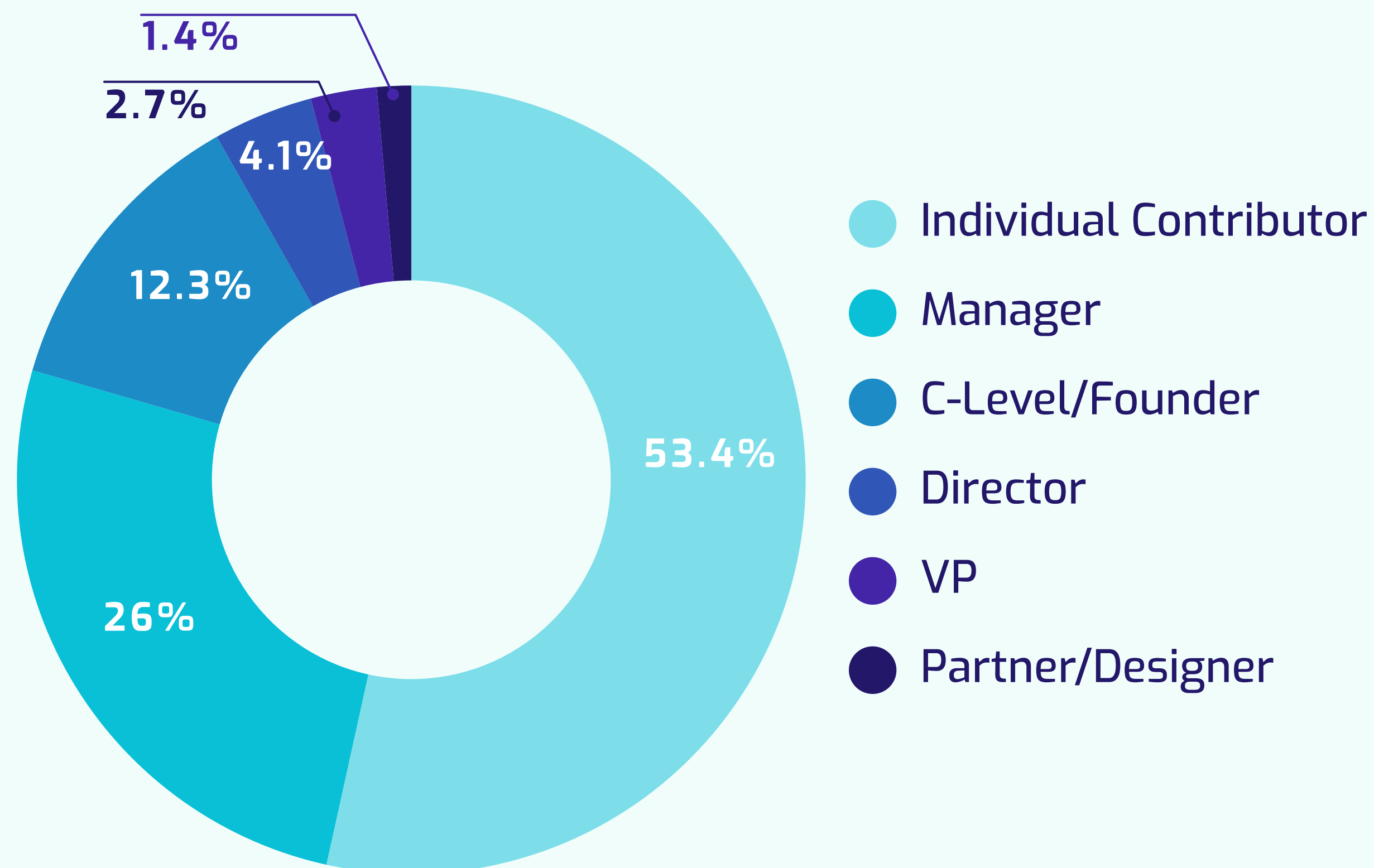
:: UX-specific Work Experience



SURVEY

WHO PARTICIPATED?

Job Level



75%

of ICs have a bachelor's degree or higher

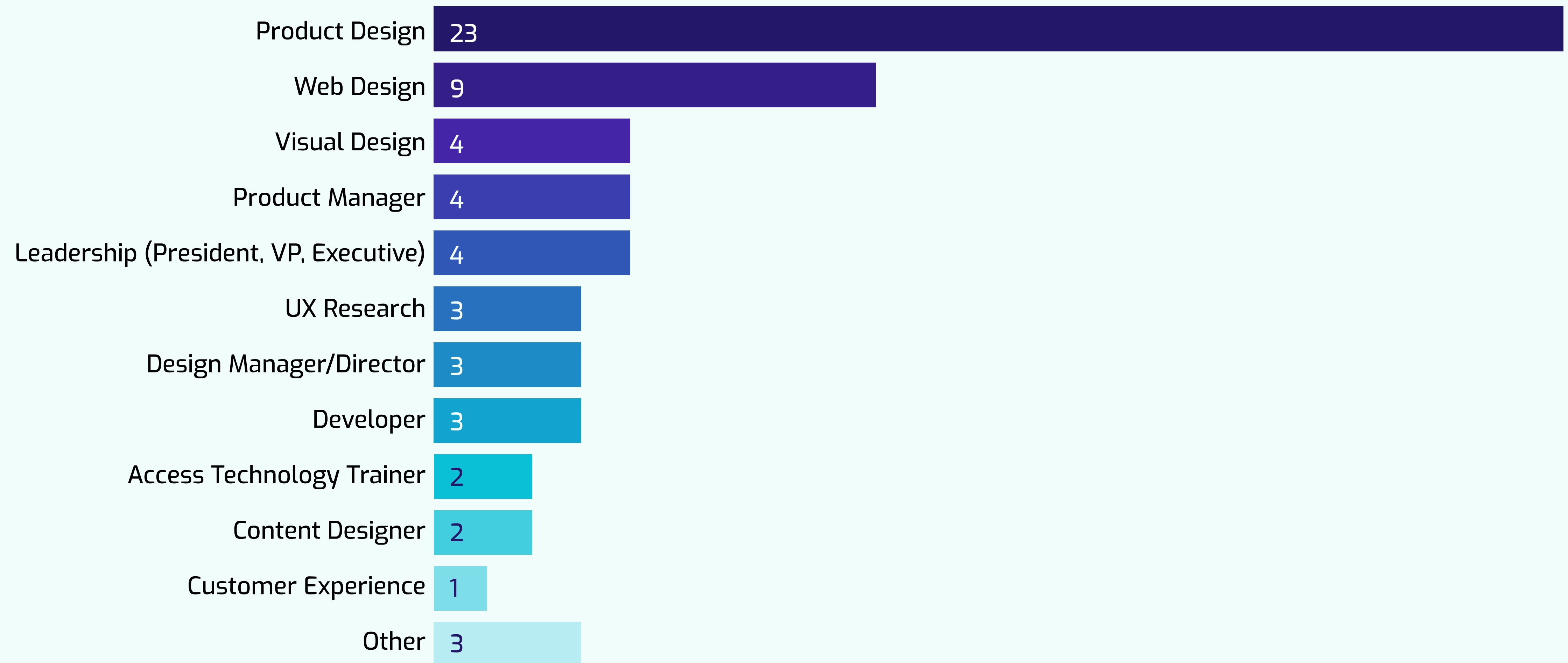
42%

of Managers have a master's degree or higher

40%

of VPs, Directors, and C-level/Founders have a bachelor's degree

Current Job Title



▶ ▶ ▶ In-Depth Interview Participants

**3****EDUCATORS**

Staff and faculty from
Kapi'olani Community
College's (KCC) New Media
Arts (NMA) Program

The NMA Program at KCC is a 2-year
AS degree program that prepares
students for employment in the
fields of interface design and
animation.

**4****UX DESIGNERS**

Practitioners who work
within a business or as
a solo entrepreneur

Practitioners we interviewed work
as a freelancer, a solo UXer on a
small team, or on a small UX
consulting group embedded in a
large locally based corporation.

**8****UX ALLIES**

Vice Presidents,
Managing Partners, and
influencers in the field

UX Allies advocate for UX in their
roles. In this study, they held roles
as VPs, managers, developers,
design partners, or consultants for
tech accelerators.



UX at Kapi'olani Community College

Since 2001, the New Media Arts program has offered a 2-year program in Interface Design, it focuses on helping students get a job locally by providing them a foundational experience in graphic and interface design, motion graphics, printing, and branding.

The combined experience of the program's faculty comprises UI Design, front end web development, print fundamentals, packaging, and identity.

They see many students come in knowing they want to do design, but not necessarily what kind of design they want to do. These educators find that Hawai'i companies look for generalist visual designers and jack-of-all-trades designers.

” The feeling of 'ohana in this program and the cohort model we have, being in the classroom with [classmates who become] their family and I see these relationships every single day. This program tremendously affects people's lives and that resonates throughout the community and is the best strength of the program and we keep that tight knit model by bringing back alumni for panels & events.”

— Educators



Career Trajectories

One of our interviewees was interested in **Print Design since High School** and learned how to use Photoshop during that time. They went to **college in the mainland** working with the college newspaper and earned a concentration in **Interface Design**. They learned UX through a combination of **self-teaching** and **mentorship**.

Currently, they are a UX/UI Designer for a small business and is **perceived as the “digital person”**, and they feel they could be implementing more UX practices on the team, but the **team is small**.

Another interviewee first worked for **6 months with a local company as a web designer**, helping to modernize early 2000-style designs.

They obtained the **Interface Design degree at KCC** where a faculty member connected them to a local design group looking for a designer with their skill sets.

The design group is contracted as the **in-house online experience team** for a major Hawai'i based company. While their experience at KCC provided them with a vast amount of information to get into the job force, there was still a lot of **UX knowledge they had to learn on the job**.



Advice for those starting out in UX

1

Personal Research

"Seek out info and knowledge because it is an ever-changing landscape."

"Explore as much as possible, for example, the NMA program serves a really good platter of everything you can do, which allows students to explore many different projects."

"Not everyone can go to the mainland for a 4 year education and have a bunch of internships, but something that is [important] is staying relevant to what is going on outside of Hawai'i, understanding that is actually your secret weapon."

2

Find a community

"Finding community group that have a value alignment, a place to build and create things together and have fun."

3

Be Resilient

"Handle criticism, because lots of students in the program took offense to it, but it's required for the job."

4

Network

"Play a networking role by connecting people together."

"Network, awesome opportunities come out of it, network and keep the connection."



Career Trajectories

One of the UX leaders we interviewed is a **developer and software engineer** who has done a lot of design work in different parts of the UX universe. They **worked on UIs in Silicon Valley** for companies like Cisco and Apple. They even worked on the **first iPhone team**, where they first experienced UX when the team was assigned its **first UX designer**.

In 2010, they moved back to Hawai'i where they **started their own company** for mobile application development. This is when mobile apps started taking over the planet. They now help local companies **bring their digital channels to life**.

Another UX Leader has been in the industry for 20 years doing **business consulting**, as well as, working with investors and different **tech accelerators in Hawai'i**. As a managing partner of a local accelerator, a big part of their job is looking at **how start-ups, mostly software companies, incorporate design** because it is an important part of how a product distinguishes themselves and represents the first impression of a company. Many of the teams they work with are distributed and the accelerator provides a **mentorship program** to help teams on both UX and UI.



Advice for those starting out in UX

1

Learn the technical skills

"I would assume they would focus on gaining skills and tools to deliver all deliverables expected. Would assume they are excellent at whatever tool (Sketch, Figma)"

2

Consider opportunities with large corporate brands

"It's hard to build a robust portfolio when you lived and worked in Hawai'i and haven't had experience in larger corporate or retail brands."

3

Develop a systemic approach

"UX designers need to fundamentally approach problems and systematically understand the flow of users and data in the system."

4

Strengthen communication skills with different stakeholders

"Need to translate what they are doing and how to speak the jargon of all stakeholders"

5

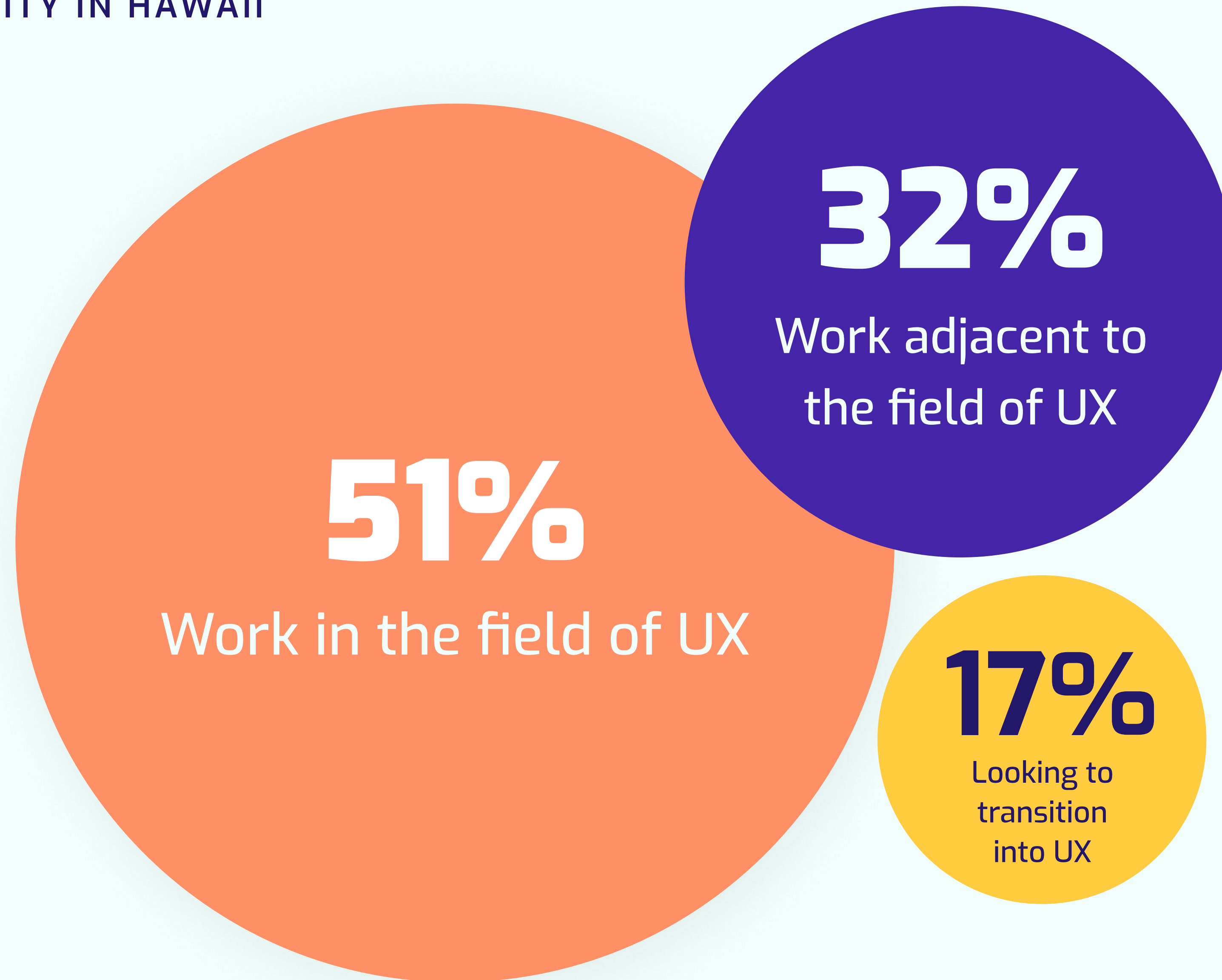
Stay curious and passionate

"Don't be concerned with not having the skills or specs. Be curious and passionate."

Our Findings

A decorative graphic consisting of several small triangles in orange, teal, and yellow, scattered around the title 'Our Findings'.

▶ ▶ ▶ What is the Professional Outlook for UXers in Hawai'i?



:: PERCENTAGES ARE BASED OFF OF OUR SURVEY PARTICIPANTS WHO ARE LOCATED IN HAWAII

There are not many local full-time UX opportunities.

33% live on the islands, but do not work for a company that operates in Hawai'i.

” It’s rare to hear graduates get a job with UX in its title. Most either freelance, get hired by agencies short-term, or move to the mainland to find work.”

— *Educators*

UXers in Hawaii are working harder...

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1 Finding consistent work

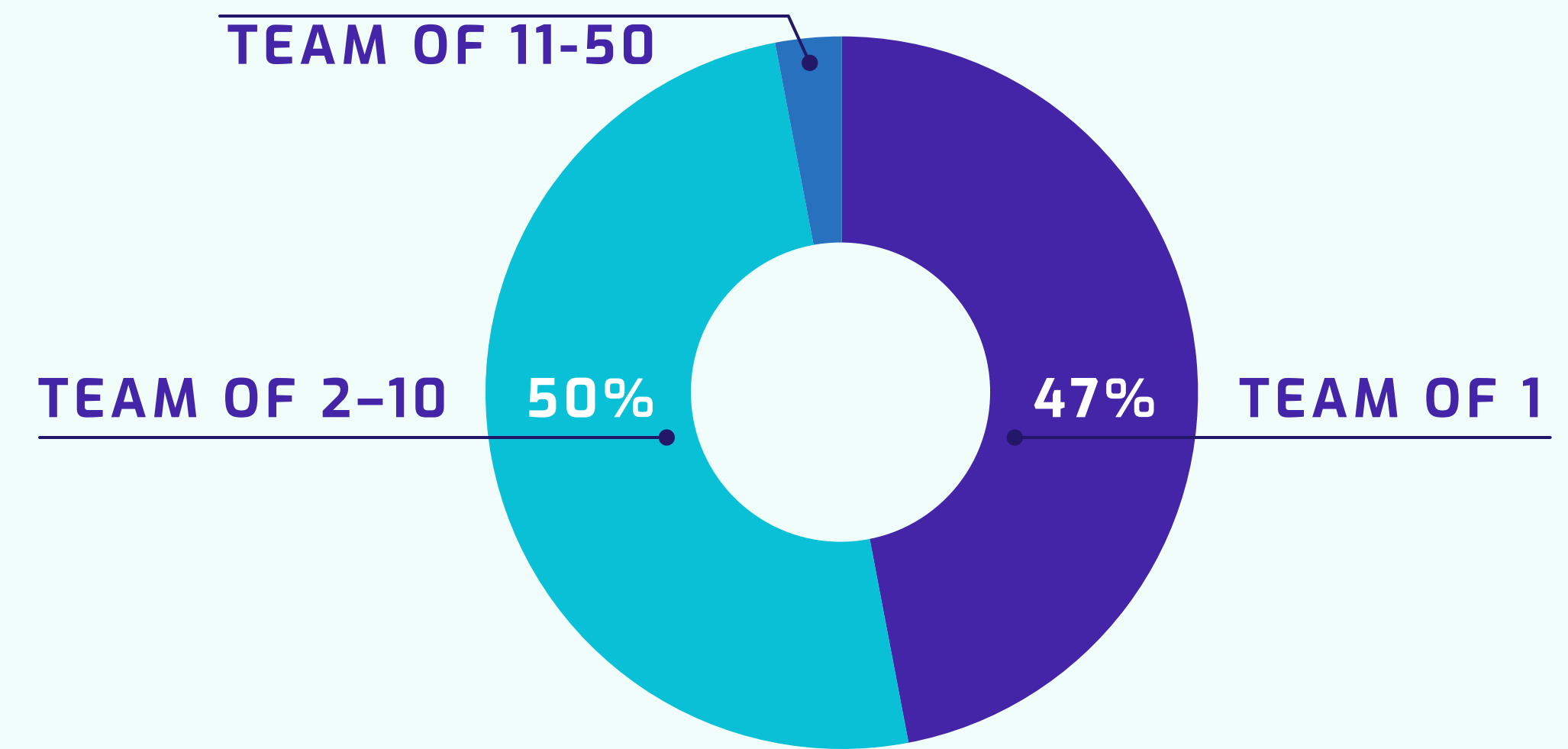
Local work is typically short-term, so consistently finding work to make a living is a job in itself.

2 Doing it all

Most are expected to be a “jack-of-all-trades” or generalist with the expectation to be able to also know how to develop.

3 As a team of 1 or in small teams

Those that are local & work for a Hawai'i-based company:



...but are not making comparable salary here.

>\$75,000

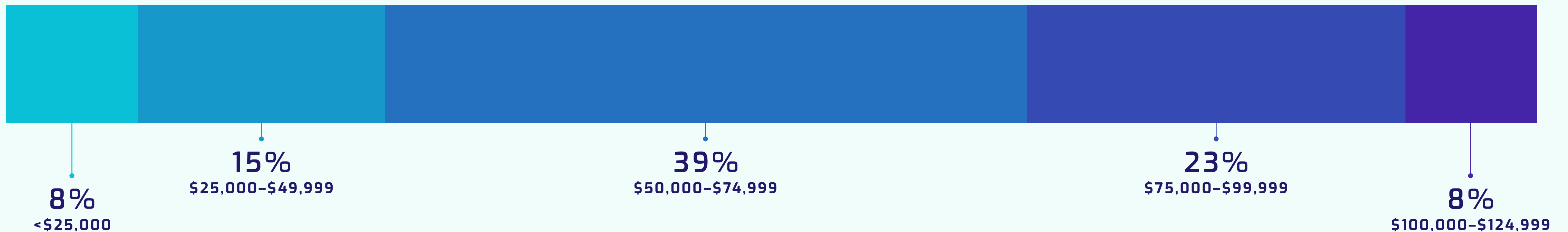
Hawai'i

vs

\$109,776

National Average

OF THE REPORTED SALARIES AS AN IC IN HAWAI'I, 62% MAKE LESS THAN \$75K.



We see the need, but they aren't hiring.

” Companies are all looking for years of experience when hiring for UX, but how can I get those years of experience if all opportunities are requiring years of experience?”

” I see the opportunity to apply UX thinking in many industries here, but those industries don't seem to see the need or aren't hiring for it.”

But, we want to stay here.



62%

intend to stay in
Hawai'i permanently.

▶ ▶ ▶ **What are the Challenges UXers
are Facing?**

UX is not
prioritized or
funded.

Many business
leaders do not
know what UX is.

The UX job
market in
Hawai'i is
limited.

TOP CHALLENGES

Many business leaders do not know what UX is.

Throughout our research, almost all UX practitioners mentioned struggling with needing to “sell” the ROI of UX, whether that was with clients or within the organization.

Companies and their leadership are unaware that UX Design expands beyond just website design, while UX practitioners all express an aligned broader definition of UX:

UX Design is
about people
and **keeping**
it human-
centered.

TOP CHALLENGES

UX is not prioritized or funded.

With the lack of understanding of UX and a culture that is reluctant to change, there is a limited budget towards UX resources and activities in local businesses.

UX positions in Hawai'i have lower pay or are limited in number, which often times leads designers to abandon it as a career option or choose to relocate.

It starts with business leadership for UX to be embraced.

There is so much opportunity, but the barrier is high.
Companies that have the money to hire aren't, or they are finding mainland talent.

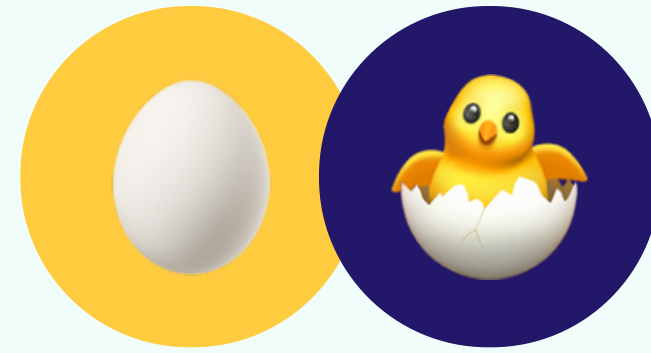
TOP CHALLENGES

UX is not prioritized or funded (cont.)

Even within local education, design educators express that they would like to support more UX skill development in their programs, but due to budget and meek potential job outcomes post-graduation, development of these courses are not prioritized.

Can't think of one graduate who has UX in their title. **Our goals are to get students a job locally.**

The UX job market in Hawai'i is limited.



IT'S A CHICKEN AND THE EGG PROBLEM

” There are not enough UX jobs in Hawai'i. They are looking for more years of experience than I have.”

“For the jobs that do exist, they aren't paying enough.”

— UX Designers

” It's hard to find good UX talent.”

“There are just larger business problems that [some companies] are going to prioritize over building out digital.”

— UX Allies

TOP CHALLENGES

The UX job market in Hawai'i is limited (cont.)

UX practitioners express that there are not enough UX roles available in Hawai'i. Engineers are often times given the added responsibility "to do UX", even though it is a specialized skillset.

If there are local UX opportunities, they tend to be agency or contract work, which has high turnover, causing difficulty to have consistent, predictable income.

However, employers we've spoken to have expressed that finding talent for UX has been challenging.

A company would really need to **commit to UX as a strategy to be able to hire in-house.**



What Can Our UX Community Do?



1

**INSPIRE LOCAL
BUSINESS
LEADERS TO
HIRE UX
PROFESSIONALS**



2

**GENERATE
OPPORTUNITIES
FOR NEW UXERS
TO GAIN
EXPERIENCE**



3

**HOST
COLLABORATIVE
EVENTS TO
STRENGTHEN
THE UX
COMMUNITY**

Inspire local businesses leaders to hire UX professionals.

- Demonstrate, educate, and communicate the Value of UX in Hawai'i (ROI).
- Encourage start-ups to invest in UX from the beginning, that's when UX can be so powerful to them.

” “Run a case study on a company and quantify what UX means to them and how it helps revenue and user acquisition, if you can make that data presentable and easily digestible, it would help others in the UX/UI field”

— UX Designer

Inspire local businesses leaders to hire UX professionals (cont.)

- Motivate local business leaders to hire in-house versus outsourcing tech talent off-island.
- Assist Hawai'i-based companies with recruitment by helping with the hiring process and potentially creating mentorship or internship programs.

” You can get [tech jobs] here. Those opportunities aren't found, they're created. That's our job, that's your kuleana”

— UX Ally, when asked if those starting in tech should go to the mainland

Generate opportunities for new UXers to gain experience and network.

- Continue inviting students to attend UXHI events for networking and educational opportunities.
- Develop relationships with partners at educational institutions so that local youth are aware of UX career paths.
- Invest in mentorship programs.

” Perhaps UXHI needs to make a little mentorship pairing service. For instance right now, I would love to hire a junior designer or an intern, no idea where to hire UX in Hawai’i”

— UX Ally

Host collaborative events to strengthen our UX community.

- Events such as:
 - In-person, social events in a relaxed environment
 - Collaborative design events
 - Conferences for networking
 - Panels, both remote and in-person

” You can create [an innovative culture] here if you want to but you can’t do that in a vacuum - you need the community to do it... It’s going to take a village, and people at all levels.”

— UX Ally

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Conclusion & Looking Forward

Next Steps for UXHI

This study has inspired UXHI to continue with their mission to support the UX community in Hawai'i. Some of our plans are as follows:

TODAY

- Continue hosting social and educational events (both in-person & virtual).
- Keep our Slack community active as a platform for resources and job postings.

TOMORROW

- Kick-off a mentorship program to connect UX professionals in Hawai'i this year.

BEYOND

- Connect with educational institutions both K-12 and post-high school for partnerships.
- Create collaborative project opportunities that demonstrate the ROI of UX.

Thank you!

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IN-DEPTH INTERVIEW PARTICIPANTS

tbd